Validation Hierarchy of Evidence

Stop guessing. Start proving.

The Hierarchy

Not all evidence is equal. This ladder goes from weakest to strongest. Students waste weeks collecting weak evidence when they should be climbing to strong evidence fast.

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STRONGEST ↑
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 LEVEL 7 │ RECURRING REVENUE
         │ Customers pay again. Retention > 40% monthly.
         │ → You have product-market fit.
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 LEVEL 6 │ REVENUE
         │ Someone paid real money. Even €1 counts.
         │ → "Will they pay?" is answered.
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 LEVEL 5 │ PRE-ORDERS / LETTERS OF INTENT
         │ Credit card entered. Contract signed.
         │ → Commitment with real stakes.
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 LEVEL 4 │ BEHAVIORAL SIGNAL
         │ Signed up. Joined waitlist. Clicked "Buy."
         │ → Actions speak louder than words.
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 LEVEL 3 │ LANDING PAGE / SMOKE TEST
         │ Built a fake door. Measured click-through.
         │ → Tested demand without building product.
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 LEVEL 2 │ CUSTOMER INTERVIEWS (Mom Test style)
         │ Talked about their past behavior & pain.
         │ → Confirmed the problem exists.
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 LEVEL 1 │ SURVEYS & QUESTIONNAIRES
         │ People said they'd want it. Maybe.
         │ → People lie on surveys. Weak signal.
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 LEVEL 0 │ YOUR OPINION / "I THINK..."
         │ You and your team think it's a good idea.
         │ → Worth exactly nothing.
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WEAKEST ↓
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The Rule

Each week, you should be one level higher than last week.

If you're still at Level 1-2 after 3 weeks, something is wrong — either the problem isn't real, or you're avoiding the scary experiments.

For Each Level: What to Do

Level	Experiment	Time to Run	Cost
2	5 customer interviews (Mom Test)	1 week	€0
3	Landing page + Google/Meta ad	2-3 days	€50-100
4	Waitlist with email capture	1 week	€0-50
5	Pre-order page or LOI outreach	1-2 weeks	€0
6	Sell manually (concierge MVP)	1-2 weeks	Your time
7	Deliver repeatedly, measure retention	4+ weeks	Variable

The Kill Question

At each level, ask: **"What would make me abandon this idea?"**

Write it down BEFORE you run the experiment. This prevents motivated reasoning — the #1 killer of student startups. You'll unconsciously interpret ambiguous data as positive unless you've pre-committed to your kill criteria.

Example:

> *"If fewer than 3 out of 10 interviewees describe this problem unprompted, the problem isn't painful enough. I'll pivot."*

Common Traps

The Survey Trap: Running a survey of 200 people feels rigorous but teaches less than 5 real conversations. Surveys can’t capture context, emotion, or follow-up questions.

The Pilot Trap: Building a “small” pilot that takes 6 weeks. If you can’t test the core assumption in under 1 week, you’re testing the wrong thing.

The Friendly Data Trap: Your friends, classmates, and professors are not your customers. Their enthusiasm means nothing. Talk to strangers who match your ICP.

The Feature Trap: “Users said they want feature X” is Level 1 evidence disguised as Level 2. What they DO matters. What they SAY they want doesn’t.